

Church AI Foundation (CAIF) Vision Brief

Toward a Trustworthy AI Foundation for Churches

Draft Version 1.0

Why This Initiative?

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is changing the world at an unprecedented pace. It is beginning to influence not only education, business, medicine, and government, but also how churches preserve knowledge, equip believers, and serve future generations.

Churches have accumulated decades of valuable experience through sermons, Bible studies, fellowship ministries, mission work, administrative decisions, and faithful service. Much of this wisdom exists only in scattered documents, emails, meeting minutes, photographs, videos, or the memories of long-serving members.

As leadership changes and volunteers rotate, valuable knowledge is often lost. New workers must repeatedly rediscover past lessons, while experienced members spend significant time answering the same questions or reconstructing historical information.

Artificial intelligence provides a new opportunity—not to replace pastors or ministry leaders—but to help preserve, organize, and responsibly share the collective wisdom God has entrusted to His church.

The Church AI Foundation (CAIF) is an exploration of how this may be accomplished.

Our Mission

The mission of CAIF is simple:

To help churches preserve, govern, and wisely apply their collective knowledge through trustworthy artificial intelligence.

Our goal is not to build "an AI church."

Our goal is to build **AI that faithfully serves the church.**

We believe technology should always remain a servant of ministry—not its master.

Why Open Source?

Churches around the world often face similar challenges:

- preserving ministry knowledge,
- training new volunteers,
- organizing historical records,
- supporting discipleship,
- improving collaboration.

Rather than each church building everything independently, CAIF proposes an open-source foundation where reusable components can be shared and improved collaboratively.

Open source allows:

- collaboration across churches,
- transparency,
- continuous improvement,
- lower development costs,
- and long-term sustainability.

The Foundation itself does not belong to one church.

Instead, churches may freely adopt, adapt, or contribute according to their own needs.

What CAIF Is — and What It Is Not

CAIF is:

- a collaborative engineering effort,

- an open-source foundation,
- a collection of reusable AI capabilities,
- a platform for responsible experimentation,
- a way to preserve institutional memory,
- a community of Christian volunteers exploring trustworthy AI.

CAIF is not:

- a replacement for pastors,
- a replacement for Biblical study,
- a replacement for human discipleship,
- an attempt to automate spiritual leadership,
- or an effort to allow AI to determine church doctrine.

Human spiritual leadership always remains essential.

Our First Goal

Rather than attempting to solve every problem immediately, CAIF begins with a small practical prototype.

The initial prototype focuses on preserving and retrieving church knowledge.

Possible examples include:

- historical administrative records,
- fellowship meeting materials,
- ministry documents,
- presentations,
- photographs,
- videos,

- organizational history.

This prototype allows us to learn gradually while serving real ministry needs.

Our Guiding Principles

The Foundation is guided by several principles.

1. Ministry Before Technology

Technology exists to serve the mission of the Church.

The mission never changes because technology changes.

2. Wisdom Before Automation

Not everything should be automated.

Some decisions require spiritual maturity, pastoral care, and prayer.

3. Truth Before Convenience

AI answers should be supported by trustworthy evidence whenever possible.

When uncertainty exists, it should be acknowledged rather than hidden.

4. Human Responsibility

AI may assist.

Humans remain responsible.

Church leaders continue to provide theological, pastoral, and organizational oversight.

5. Stewardship

Church knowledge is a valuable resource entrusted by God.

Preserving and sharing that knowledge responsibly is an act of faithful stewardship.

Collaboration

CAIF welcomes volunteers with many different backgrounds.

Some may contribute software.

Others may contribute ministry experience.

Others may review documents, organize historical materials, improve Biblical resources, or help evaluate AI-generated responses.

Everyone has something valuable to contribute.

Looking Forward

Artificial Intelligence will continue to evolve rapidly.

Specific technologies will change.

Software platforms will come and go.

Programming methods will continue to evolve.

However, the Church's mission remains unchanged.

CAIF therefore seeks to build upon enduring principles rather than temporary technologies.

Our hope is that future generations of believers will inherit not only better software, but also a richer understanding of the faithfulness, wisdom, and experiences of those who served before them.

A Biblical Foundation

"On that day I will restore David's fallen shelter. I will repair its broken walls and restore its ruins, and will rebuild it as it used to be."

Amos 9:11

Joshua Fellowship has often embraced this passage as a reminder that God calls His people to "repair the broken places." While this originally speaks of God's redemptive work, it also inspires our ministry today: preserving institutional memory, strengthening ministry continuity, and helping future servants build upon the faithful work of those who came before them.

We view CAIF as one practical way to support that calling—using modern technology to help "repair the gaps" in organizational memory so that the church may continue serving God more effectively.

Closing Remarks

CAIF is not primarily a software project.

It is a ministry of stewardship.

Its purpose is to help the Church remember.

To help future servants learn.

To preserve faithful experience.

And ultimately,

to ensure that knowledge accumulated through decades of ministry can continue to bless future generations.

"One generation shall commend your works to another, and shall declare your mighty acts." (*Psalms 145:4, ESV*)